

THE YEAR WAS 140 CHARACTERS

From Twitter's pointless babble to the ego massages of social networks to TV's extremes, 2009 belonged to the digerati

By Dilip Bobb

Is the person who joins Twitter a twit? What explains this sudden urge to inform the world what you had for dinner? Why would you subject friends and colleagues to the daily minutiae of your life? How much of trivia can people absorb? These were all absorbing questions in a year when trivia and ambient intimacy formed an electronic signature, ceaseless, often mindless, chatter for an age when little of note seemed like a lot. We even appointed a twitter minister, or was it self-appointed,

ment by the photogenic, telegenic, digigenic Shashi Tharoor? Our dwindling attention spans denied us an answer but it was a fitting enough symbol, fingers flying across characters and numbers as we scrabbled to take narcissism to a new level. I, me, myself, this is what I do, what I eat, what I'm wearing and where I'm going to be tonight.

Or, joined together on Facebook, it was: Look Ma, how many friends I have! It was a young generation's tool and language usurped by middle-aged parents and elders in a desperate bid to be up with the latest fad and, hey, let's not forget the 15 minutes of fame. For, in the end, that's what it boiled down to, the blogs, the tweets, Facebook, Orkut, LinkedIn, et al, one amorphous, egocentric network. Ego went electronic and forced everybody to show how important their lives were. The most-asked request on everyone's inbox was: "Mr/Ms... invites you to join his/her network." Vague acquaintances be-

came instant, intimate friends and then you were obliged to view their blogs. Invisible, even non-existent readers and viewers, but in an exploding cyberspace everybody found voice, a digital soapbox to rant and rave and rage against anything and anybody. It also became status. You didn't blog, you didn't count. It was a false premise, and ultimately, a declaration of dependence. You are, therefore I am. I follow you, you follow me. Psychologists call it the "small world phenomenon" based on the hypothesis that the chain of social acquaintances required to connect one arbitrary person to another arbitrary person anywhere in the world requires just six degrees of separation.

Technology governed our lives like never before, and it wasn't all good. Even Tharoor, trapped in an austerity drive, got rapped for his cattle class, holy cow remark. That, however, lay at the core of the year's big social revolution. Caught in a downturn, or in austerity

drive, self-obsessed, self-promoting technological tools became our coping mechanism. Check out another digital network, satellite tv, and the story was pretty much the same. The highest TRPS were for kitschy reality shows where semi-celebs sought a suitable bride or a bridegroom, live, from a host of applicants. Rakhi Sawant and Rahul Mahajan, one a much-botoxed babe in low-cut outfits, the other a briefly married man with little on his cv except as the son of a high-flying politician and *Big Boss* contestant. Like Facebook, twitters and blogs, it was another way of desperately seeking fame, the ultimate expression of a celebrity-addled generation who believe their every move and utterance is fascinating and ought to be shared with the world, even if it was embarrassing.

As reality tv got more extreme, one show-and-tell had participants subjecting themselves to lie detector tests and then appearing live on national networks, facing intimate questions about issues like extra-marital affairs, domestic violence and other indiscretions. The prudes fumed and fulminated but as a sign of the times, it was entirely suitable. Fame has come to so many who didn't deserve it, so why should we be left out? The medium became the message as television played up loves and lives of strangers and semi-entities. Attention spans had shrunk, and the TRPS showed it. Major news stories became media overkill and then vanished, to be replaced by the next exclusive or breaking news

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